

Gender inequality is a well-known challenge with significant effects on socioeconomic progress, mainly when analyzed through the perspective of economic complexity – a country's capacity to produce a diverse range of sophisticated goods and services (Hidalgo & Hausmann, 2009; Hidalgo et al., 2007). Addressing gender inequality in this context is important because strong empirical evidence shows that greater gender equality fosters economic complexity by expanding women's roles in productive sectors. For example, improving health and education outcomes, as well as empowering women's socioeconomic and political participation (Nguyen, 2021).

Addressing gender inequality is not only a matter of social justice but also a way to enhance economic complexity. The integration of gender inequality and the Economic Complexity Index (ECI) in research began to emerge prominently in the early 2020s. One of the first comprehensive studies explicitly linking gender equality and economic complexity using the ECI was published by Nguyen in 2021. This study analyzed data from 119 countries and demonstrated how gender equality in employment, education, health, and rights affects economic complexity, as measured by the ECI (Nguyen, 2021). Before this, research on economic complexity and gender inequality existed in parallel, but the systematic combination of these two fields – using the ECI as a central metric – gained momentum only in the last few years, with increasing attention from both economists and social scientists (Nguyen, 2021; Sajid et al., 2025).

Gender inequality and economic complexity are approached in research, business, and policy through multidimensional analyses and targeted interventions. Research highlights that gender equality in employment, education, health, and rights has a positive impact on economic complexity, with studies showing that inclusive policies and governance institutions enhance both economic sophistication and trade openness (Nguyen, 2021; Sajid et al., 2025). Businesses are increasingly adopting diversity initiatives to enhance innovation and competitiveness, while policymakers are implementing gender-inclusive strategies to promote sustainable development and equitable growth (World Economic Forum, 2025; Bennett, 2024). These efforts are supported by empirical evidence and global benchmarks, emphasizing the interconnectedness of gender equality and economic advancement.

The entire topic is not widely researched; however, an additional step could be to consider the implications of introducing a new layer in the form of networks. With a better understanding of the network structure – specifically, small-world networks among people – we can mediate the relationship between gender equality and economic complexity. While existing research establishes the positive impact of gender equality on economic complexity, less is known about how the architecture of professional and social networks shapes women's access to opportunities and resources, and how this influences economic diversification and innovation. My research proposal focuses on how small-world network characteristics moderate the impact of gender equality on economic complexity across different economies. This topic examines the mechanisms by which network inclusivity and connectivity impact the translation of gender equality into tangible economic outcomes, providing actionable insights for policymakers and organizations seeking to promote inclusive growth.

A stakeholder interested in the results of research on the above-mentioned topic would be national policymakers, particularly those responsible for economic development and gender equality initiatives. These policymakers would benefit by gaining evidence-based insights into how to design more effective interventions that promote inclusive economic growth. Understanding the role of network structure can help them target policies to improve women's access to influential networks, thereby enhancing economic diversification, innovation, and resilience. This supports broader national goals of sustainable development and equitable prosperity.

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